

The Unknown Tower and Halls

By Steven K Allen

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lycanthrope (weretiger), while Darien worships Jiathuli¹⁹, and is the most introverted of the sisters and keeps mostly to herself. The male Drow fighters are led by Algorand who secretly plots to wrestle control of the enclave from Madame Nova, and feels resentment that his god has favored her, a mere woman. As most Drow societies are matriarchal, the followers of Vhaeraun are mostly males who desire to instill a patriarchic society which they see as the natural order. Algorand is patient and while he has not yet swayed enough of the males to his side, he is patient, and willing to wait before attempting a coup. Madame Nova was not truthful about the nature of some of the natural caverns within the area and Algorand may depart this information if he feels that it would benefit him. The reasons that Madame Nova lied about the natural caverns is to protect the Drow's territory and to prevent the adventurers from discovering other Drow strongholds in the area. The disinformation also protects the Drow from being discovered because the characters may run into other Drow from nearby cities.

Armed with the rough map and information the Drow release the adventurers back into the halls, but they blindfold them and wrap them in globes of darkness so that they cannot find the enclave's secret entrances. Detailing the rest of the enclave is up to the DM, but the characters are not intended to enter past room #6, where all business dealings will be carried out in the future.

Room #7.

Opening the last door on the southern wall reveals a wide room that is 15' square. The room has a ceiling that is 10' high and is very hot and dry. In the center of should have been the southern wall, there is empty space and a narrow 5'-wide stone bridge without a handrail. This bridge spans an immense cavern of indeterminable depth but is only 60' wide. Relentless waves of intense heat rise from the depths of the chasm and a miasma of sulphur washes over the bridge filling the room. Apparently made of solid stone, the bridge arches gently in the center. Faint dwarven runes engraved upon both sides of the bridge ask for the blessing of (Dwarven god).

The adventurers can safely cross the bridge quickly reaching the landing upon the other side, which is identical to the previous room. The heat over the center of the bridge is intense (around 145° Fahrenheit) and dawdling adventurers might suffer some damage. A character reading the dwarven runes along the bridge aloud and in the mountain dwarven tongue enacts a special *Bless* spell that protects everyone crossing the bridge, prevents damage from the heat, and gives a +1 bonus to all saving throws for 1d4 rounds. At the bottom of the chasm is a large pool of lava, and characters falling off the bridge are lost forever.

Room #8, Opposite Landing.

This landing is identical to the one that you just left except reversed. Upon the southern door is another single stone door shut tightly. Painted in black ink directly in the center of the door is the Drow word "sreen."

The door bears a 16th-level *Wizard Lock* spell. Sreen is a common Drow word to indicate danger. The door is trapped with a poisonous gas globe trap. Opening the door without disarming the trap releases four glass globes from the roof that shatter upon the stone floor releasing a poisonous gas cloud that effects everything within 15' of the door. Characters caught within the poisonous gas cloud must roll a successful save versus poison or suffer 4d6 points of damage.

Room #9, Danger Apparent.

Opening the door reveals a 10' long and 15' long wide room with a ceiling 12' tall. This room has a descending flight of stone stairs on the southern wall. Standing in front of this door is a large eight-foot tall, golden humanoid that glows with a crackling light like Saint Elmo's fire. Occasionally you see bright bolts of electricity arc from the trunk of the figure strike its upraised arms.

This creature is the lightning golem that Madame Nova warned the adventurers about and it has been here a long time. How the Drow figured out the password is unknown, and it is quite possible that the dwarves constructed the golem and placed it here as a guardian. Speaking the password (which is the command word for the golem as well) allows the characters to pass the golem safely accessing the stairs. Since the golem contains a large amount of gold, the characters might get greedy and attack the golem anyway despite the Drow's warning. Although the characters might have said the command word, attacking the golem causes it to retaliate. Repeating the command word after attacking the golem has no effect, and the golem will continue to attack the characters until they either are killed or flee the room across the bridge. The golem will not chase the characters across the bridge or down the stairs, and characters that rush past the golem and although suffering the attacks of the golem, reach the safety of the stairs, are safe and may continue to the bottom of the stairs.

Lightning golem: Intelligence 2-4 Semi-intelligent; AL N; AC 0; MV 12; HD 11; hp 55; THAC0 9; #AT 1; Dmg 4d8; SA See Below; SD See Below; SZ L; ML Fearless (19-20); XP 2,004.

The lightning golem moves much more quickly than one might expect an automaton to move. Because of this, it gains a +2 bonus to all initiative rolls that it is called upon to make.

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When in close combat, the lightning golem lashes out with its metallic arms, trying to strike its enemies. Anyone hit by the being suffers 4d8 points of damage from the blow and its associated electrical shock. Anyone making a successful saving throw vs. spells or with some immunity to electrical damage suffers only half damage. Persons who fail their saves may be required (at the DM's option) to make saving throws for some or all of the items they are carrying.

If possible, the golem begins combat by unleashing a powerful stroke of chain lightning at its enemies. This attack is similar to that of the sixth-level wizard spell of the same name and has a range of 50 yards. The stroke inflicts 6d6 points of damage to the first target that it strikes.

Because of the inorganic nature of this being, the lightning golem is immune to all manner of life affecting magic or psionic powers. Thus, attempts to put it to sleep or cause disease fail. Spells and powers that influence the mind are similarly useless against this automaton. Attacks that depend upon heat or fire affect the golem normally, causing its golden skeleton to melt and deform. Those based on cold, ice, lightning, or electricity are ineffective. Spells and abilities that have power over metal, such as crystalbrittle, have their normal effects upon the lightning golem.

Lightning golems are considered greater golems, and are thus always under the control of their creator.

The golem is made of about 2,000 pounds of gold and if the characters destroy it, the DM should be strict with encumbrance for greedy characters. I would not allow the characters to attain that much wealth but each DM is free to run this adventure as he sees fit.

When the characters commence their descent of the stairs read the following:

The stairs descend 190' at a gentle 15° angle and as you descend farther into the earth the temperature drops noticeably and at the bottom, the temperature is the underground ambient temperature. The stairs end in a simple plain stone door with an iron bas-relief face of a large bull with great sweeping horns. Swinging from the bull's mouth through its teeth is a great large iron ring like some sort of subterranean doorknocker. As you approach (within 10'), the "doorknocker" bull's eyes begin to glow with a dark red light.

Casting *Detect Magic* upon the doorknocker reveals that it is quite magical and a simple (+15% chance of success) successful find traps roll discovers that the bull is also trapped. A simple and successful disarm traps roll (+15% chance of success) removes a single dart trap. The characters have the password to safely pass this trap, which is quite dangerous. Speaking the pass-phrase "jal khaless zhah waela" (all truth is foolish) in Drow deactivates the gas trap, and unless the characters miss the simple dart trap, the door opens swiftly upon speaking the pass-phrase. The eyes of the bull glow with the dark light until the trap is deactivated. The trap is only deactivated for 12 hours each time the phrase is spoken.

Touching any part of the door or the doorknocker without speaking the pass-phrase causes a billowing gas cloud to pour from the bull's mouth. This gas cloud has the same effect as the breath of a gorgon and affects everyone within 20' of the door. Characters caught within the gas cloud must save versus petrification or be turned into stone. The trap will release its gas cloud three times per day and then go dormant for 24 hours, during which time it replenishes its gas supply. During the time that the trap is dormant, the door is effectively locked and unable to be opened. It is possible to use magic to pass the door, or force the door open requiring 97 hp of damage.

Room #10.

This large, dark musty smelling room is 45' wide and 35' long. Apparently, this room must have once been a meeting hall or dining room some time in the past. In the center of the room is a broken great stone table in numerous pieces. Several rotting chairs scattered about this room and the debris upon the floor indicates that this room sees little use. The only exit from this room is an odd, rusty iron-reinforced wooden (oak) door. On this side of the door, the entire front of the door bears rusty but still effective spikes and the facing wall towards where the door opens is pitted with indentations from these spikes. The hinges to this door are on the left hand side and are unusually thick with large hasps and thick barrels.

Searching the room reveals a pair of useless rusty daggers, 2 gp, and a tarnished silver necklace worth about 5 gp. The spiked door is locked but with such a simple lock that a +45% chance of success applies. A *Detect Magic* spell reveals that the door is magical. However, as soon as the door is unlocked it slams open on the spring-loaded hinges, pinning man-sized and smaller creatures to the wall unless a successful Dexterity check is rolled. The door resets itself the next melee round after pinning something to the wall. Damage done to creatures struck by the door is 4d6 points. A detect traps roll identifies the trap but there is no way to disarm it other than destroying the door requiring 76 hp of damage be done to the door. Magic may be used to bypass the door, but the nature of its enchantment prevents spells like *Knock* from working upon the door, but spells like *Dispel Magic* deactivates the door for one melee round per level of the caster. While the door is deactivated, it may be picked and then pulled open by grasping the spikes. Characters that attempt to unlock the door from the side and let the door slam open must roll both a successful pick locks and Dexterity check to avoid damage from the door. Characters upon the side of the door attempting to pick it that failed

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their Dexterity check only suffer one-fourth damage from the door. Opening the door reveals another flight of stairs descending at a gentle 17° angle.

Room #11, The snail's trail.

When the character reach midpoint upon the stairs read the following:

There appears to have been a small earthquake recently as there is cracks within the stone and two gaping holes in the walls. The holes reveal a natural chasm running north and south. Every surface of this cavern glistens with a faint iridescence. The southern portion of this cavern extends past the limits of your sight and is lost in the gloom of the underworld. A strong odor of sulphur emits from the chasm.

If the characters ignore the Drow's well-meaning misdirection and explore the chasm, they discover a strange kind of lichen that emits a strange amount of faint light. Collecting some of this lichen the characters can fashion torches and lamps that require no heat and last 1d6 turns since harvesting. Storing lichen in containers like *Portable Holes*, *Bags of Holding* etc. results in the lichen lasting longer.

While searching the lichen-covered chasm, the characters discover a small brackish water stream running through the center of the chasm. Unfortunately the water contained within the stream is unfit to drink, it is heavily polluted with heavy salts, minerals, and sulphur. Characters can collect the water and purify it utilizing magic, but not enough water produced in this manner will support up to six characters under heavy exertion. Contently munching on lichen along this is a huge snail with twin round balls on its tail. Unless the characters molest the snail, it continues to feed peacefully. Attacking the snail causes it to relentlessly retaliate.

Flail snail 6 HD: Intelligence 5-7 Low intelligence; AL N; AC 4 (flail), -8 (body); MV 3; HD 6; hp 36; THAC0 15; #AT 5 (1 per tentacle); Dmg 1d8; SA Nil; SD See below; SZ L; ML Elite (13-14); XP 1,000.

A hit by a single tentacle causes 1d8 points of damage and can smash a one-inch-thick piece of wood. A four-tentacled snail makes four attacks as a 4 Hit Die creature, a three-tentacled snail makes three attacks as a 3 Hit Die creature, and so on. These attacks may be against one or two opponents. Both opponents must be in front of or to the side of the snail.

Flail snail tentacles have 1 Hit Die apiece. Treat each tentacle as a separate creature. When a tentacle is reduced to 0 hit points it is useless. Flail snails attack until all of their tentacles are dead. Once this happens the monster withdraws into its shell and dies 1d3 turns later. During these turns the snail utters pitiful cries that are 50% likely per turn to attract a wandering monster.

The body has hit points equal to the combined total of all the tentacles, but it is nearly impossible to attack because it is protected by the creature's shell. The effective Armor Class of the body is -8.

Flail snails are protected against magic by their colorful shell. Whenever the snail is attacked by magic, the effects are variable-40% chance of the spell malfunctioning, 30% chance of it functioning normally, 20% chance of it failing to work at all, and a 10% chance that the spell is reflected back at the spellcaster. A spell that malfunctions has its effect altered slightly (DM discretion). The altered spell then affects the creature nearest the snail (saving throw if applicable).

Flail snails are immune to fire and poison, but they shun bright light.

Searching the chasm takes a full day; during which time other denizens of the deep, including other Drow attracted by the ruckus of a battle, attack. There are other passages leading from this cavern and the characters could take any of these exploring the Underdark more. Revealed by searching the chasm are 36 gp, 4 sp, and a single rusty iron sword. All the items retrieved come from a Drow corpse that probably did not heed the warning about staying on the path.

Returning to the stairs and continuing down reveals that they end in a plain, untrapped, and unlocked stone door that opens easily.

Room #12.

Opening the door into this room reveals a large, dark room 30' wide and 15' long with a cathedraled roof that arches to a point 15' high. Dust-encrusted spider webs fill the room. Hacked through the webs is a trail leading to the only apparent exit. Near the center of the room, a dried hacked corpse of a huge spider lies on the floor.

Searching the room reveals nothing of interest but some useless rusty armor and weapons. Several desiccated cadavers of various underground species still cocooned in dusty spider webs. Searching these cocoons reveals nothing since they were ransacked long ago. The spider is quite dead and probably slain by dwarves or other subterranean explorers since Drow revere spiders so much. The door from this room is unlocked, untrapped and opens easily revealing a flight of stone steps rising at a steep 55° angle. As the characters reach midpoint upon the stairs, the air gets noticeably warmer and then returns to ambient underground temperature at the top. At the top of the stairs is another simple stone door identical to the previous one.